GOOGLE

PRODUCT / PROGRAM MANAGER & TAM / ASSOCIATE

JOB INTERVIEW PROCESS, QUESTIONS AND INSIGHTS

Hello,

I have successfully interviewed with Google for a product manager role very recently and outlined my experience step by step in this document.

I have also added the following information in this document:

- Questions I've been asked during my pm interviews and my suggested answers.
- Steps for applying & getting an interview with Google.
- Guide to answering questions asked in Google interviews.
- Additional recent questions that are relevant for various roles at Google, and our answers/tips for them.

Disclaimer: This guide is created by ex-Googlers. Google obviously does not endorse or approve it. This guide reflects personal experiences and general advice about the interview process.

Good luck with your interviews!

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SECTION 1

HOW TO GET AN INTERVIEW AT GOOGLE

HOW TO GET AN INTERVIEW AT GOOGLE?

Google, once only an internet search engine, is now a global tech giant with many products such as Gmail and consumer electronics (Pixelbook, Google Home). It now has offices in many countries and it is one of the hottest companies to work for.

Google gets more than 1 million job applications each year. Needless to say, it is getting harder and harder to secure a job here.

HOW TO GET AN INTERVIEW AT GOOGLE?

There are basically 3 ways to get an interview Google:

1. Employee referral: If you can find a friend/person who can refer you through the internal ATS (Applicant Tracking System), that is the fastest way to get an interview with Google. (That is how I got an interview).
2. Apply through the company website.
3. Watch out for “Hiring Events / HR Road Trips” that will happen in your city. You can find out those by following some Google HR folks on LinkedIn.

Tip: Referrals are obviously the quicker way of getting an interview!

In my case, I got a referral via a person at Google from a similar / close team to the role I've interviewed for. If you can, try to find somebody from Google who knows about that role and have a friendly chat about the role and its responsibilities.

SECTION 2

MY INTERVIEW STEPS

MY INTERVIEW STEPS

The interview steps I had was as follows:

1. Initial phone/video *screening(chat)* with a recruiter
2. Next, phone/video chat interview with a hiring manager
3. Then, phone/video interview with another member of the team
4. Final step: onsite interviews

* Please note that your interview steps may obviously be different than mine, depending on your role/location and/or team or other factors.

1. Initial phone (video chat) *screening* with a recruiter

This is the initial phone call where the recruiter actually tries to understand your motivation, your willingness to join Google and your general culture-fit. At this stage you do not need to have detailed product information. You will also most likely not be asked case questions at this stage (The initial phone screening is the easiest part of the interviews, but nevertheless you should prepare well for it, practicing possibile questions & answers).

1. Initial phone (video chat) *screening* with a recruiter

Tips for this screening round: Know why you are looking to apply to Google, why the PM role and what skills are transferrable to Google. Very important to communicate that you are data driven, customer focused and can take ownership. Projects / experiences to highlight: analytical projects, experience working with cross-functional teams, experience using customer insight / customer data to make decisions.

2. Phone/video chat interview with a hiring manager

You will normally get an email from your recruiter about this next stage. The email I got from the recruiter was this:

This phone interview will cover your experience and how it relates to the team and position. You will be speaking directly with a manager or member of the team that is currently working in this space. Our goal during the call is to introduce you to our team and gauge your fit for Google.

2. Phone/video chat interview with a hiring manager

For this interview, make sure to prepare 3-4 unique stories that are examples of key product/team management principles. As a part of this interview step, the interviewer will be mainly looking for how well you fare on each of the following key principles:

1. Users come first
2. You are data driven
3. You are a “go-getter“
4. You see the big picture

Tip: ***During preparing your own answer to each of the questions found in this guide, think about how your answers touch those 4 points above.***

2. Phone/video chat interview with a hiring manager

"Users come first"

Question: "Here is your first dilemma as a PM: You have to choose between a product feature launch and a product bug fix. Which one would you choose and why?"

For this question, it is important to base your answer to a story where you persisted and recommended a feature or bug fix based on data analysis (tip: Google LOVES when you are a data oriented person. You live and breathe with numbers!). It is generally better to serve the customers first, i.e. bugfix is the way to go. Bonus points if you had to convince someone / got pushback on your recommendation.

2. Phone/video chat interview with a hiring manager

"You are a data driven person"

Question: "How would you design an intelligent lawnmower? How would you go about it? Can you walk me through the process?"

For this question, it is important to highlight the complexity of the situation. Why is the problem challenging? What kind of data/metrics you need for the design? What makes the solution non-obvious? What is your thought process in solving this problem? What were the alternatives you consider?

*For this question and for some other questions, I gave the "answering approach" instead of giving a detailed answer. This is because those are commonly asked questions and I realized that people tend to copy this answer & recruiters recognize it when many people gives the same answer to a question. This will be a negative point for you during your interview. It is better to create an answer on your own by following the suggested answering approach above.

2. Phone/video chat interview with a hiring manager

"You are a go-getter"

Question: "How do you make a decision about X (new product, feature etc.) in the absence of data / analysis? What guides your decision-making? What were the trade-offs you will make?"

Here, talk about a situation where you were not able to analyze either due to time or information constraints. You'll need to think of an example where you relied on available data but you had a hands-on approach to solve the issue at hand and instead of waiting for it to be solved, you actively participated in the process.

2. Phone/video chat interview with a hiring manager

"You see the big picture"

Question: "How do you drive adoption for your vision/ideas? How do you know how well your idea or vision has been adopted by other teams or partners? Give a specific example highlighting one of your ideas."

For questions about "seeing the big picture", talk about a situation where you saw an opportunity to do something big that the team had completely missed. (e.g. scenarios: where you fundamentally rethink how things are done.)

continued on the next slide...

2. Phone/video chat interview with a hiring manager

"You see the big picture"

Google likes product managers who conceive solutions that challenge the status quo with initiatives such as Google Checkout (automating checkout process, rather than thinking of incremental improvements to reduce time taken for checkout). Highlight the assumptions/processes you will fundamentally question/revisit and how they will be changed.

2. Phone/video chat interview with a hiring manager

Recruiter/hiring manager will ask: “Do you have any questions for me?”

Have 3-4 thoughtful questions to the interviewer − Sample questions:

- How Google PM’s / TAM’s think about their projects,
- What are some of the things they like / dislike about the role and Google?
- What are the current problems the team is working on?

Make sure to communicate that you have the skills to do well on the job - e.g. being data driven, being tech-savvy.

3. Phone/video interview with another member of the team

This interview will be a similar one to the previous interview. Remember that both interviewers are also trying to gauge your cultural fit to the team as well.

Don’t forget to be nice and friendly while also showing your motivation and PM skills!

3. Phone/video interview with another member of the team

For this round, also prepare 2-4 different stories that focus on some other aspects of product/project management skills. (Don’t worry, you will see many questions & answers about these skills in the final section of this Guide)

Have 3-4 questions for interviewer. Show passion for working at Google.

In the next few slides you’ll see the PM & TAM related questions asked to me and my colleagues recently and our answer approached to them.

3. Phone/video interview with another member of the team

Question: “Tell me what you would do if you found out that a metric of a product dropped by 60% overnight? How would you find out where the problem lies?”

Answering Approach: *Talk about how you will start from the basics and go up in the process list to identify the cause. Do not forget to count in the external factors as well.* ***The key here is <u>not</u> to start guessing what the problems may be.*** *Instead, look at the data in hand and try to derive assumptions using those.*

3. Phone/video interview with another member of the team

Question: “Are you a short-term goal person or a long-term goal person? How does this relate to a product you manage? What did you do?”

Answering Approach: *Trick question: Being a long-term thinker is almost always better. Unless there is a specific case given to you that needs to be solved in very short time, long-term approach is the way to go. For these types of questions, think about a situation where you had to think long term. There was an easier solution that would yield results in the short-term, but might lead to problems later on. What was the situation? How did you approach the situation? How did you get buy-in to your approach?*

4. Onsite Interviews

- During onsite interviews, you will meet with 4-6 people from your potential team and possibly one person from a different team *(I had one person from another team which my team was working closely)*.

- All of them ask questions based on some cases about product/team/ project management or design.

- Please be prepared to have 3-4 stories about a project/product you have managed successfully.

- The person from the visiting team can ask further details about your stories so be prepared to share specific details.

4. Onsite Interviews

Next few slides shows a sample of the questions that have been recently asked to various “manager” candidates and our answers/suggested approaches to them.

4. Onsite Interviews

Question:

“Google is thinking of launching a premium color version of the Pixel 2 phone.

How would you quantify the benefits of this service?”

4. Onsite Interviews

Answering Approach:

When Google (or any other company) is considering launching a new service or feature, the first thing that product managers should evaluate is whether the product / feature benefits the customers and if there is a market for it. Some questions to bring up to demonstrate customer orientation are:

- *Phone sales accounts for what proportion of total hardware sales globally?*
- *Within Google, phone sales accounts for what proportion of total hardware sales?*
- *If there is a significant difference in what competitors' offer and what Google currently offers?*
- *Some of the ways we can check whether a feature is important to customers is through consumer surveys, analyzing historical data on past product launches and the impact on customer behavior.*

4. Onsite Interviews

Question:

“An engineer comes and tells you that he has launched a premium Android OS version for Pixel phones, but for some reason some customers are being charged more than normal for this feature. What will you do? How will you resolve the situation?”

4. Onsite Interviews

Answering Approach:

- *Identify why the customers were incorrectly charged (e.g. bug in the feature).*
- *After understanding the root cause for the incorrect charges, evaluate if there might be many other customers who might have been incorrectly charged.*
- *Analyze the total number of customers impacted (i.e. who have been incorrectly charged for this feature).*
- *Communicate to all customers impacted that they have been incorrectly charged for this and that their account will be shortly credited the incorrect payment.*
- *To compensate for the incorrect charge, compensate the customers with some Google Play Store credit.*

4. Onsite Interviews

Question:

“What are the steps in product development? If you are a PM, what are some of the steps / ways in which you would go about building new features?”

4. Onsite Interviews

Answering Approach:

- *The first step in product development is to understand what is the customer need / pain point that the product / feature is trying to solve? Is the problem / pain point big enough / pressing enough to be solved?*

- *Once the customer impact has been established, define what is the list of things that the product needs to address - jobs to be done. What benefits should the product offer to the user?*

- *After defining the product / solution requirements, prioritize the features to be built. You can prioritize features based on number of customers impacted, degree of impact, engineering resources required, and time it will take to be built. One way would be to prioritize features that impact a large number of customers significantly but require few engineering resources and can be implemented in a short span of time.*

4. Onsite Interviews

Question:

“Google is launching a website to specifically sell it’s hardware offerings and is thinking the delivery options available to the customer. There are many different options in delivery experience - same day delivery, 2 hour delivery and 2 day delivery and no-rush delivery.

How would you decide which delivery option to show to which customer?”

4. Onsite Interviews

Answering Approach:

Some of the methods / data used to decide which delivery experience to recommend to customers are:

- *Based on products ordered, some product categories such as Pixel might be better suited for same day delivery options.*
- *Location of the customer - do they live close to a Google office? If yes, then does it make sense to promote office pick-up?*
- *Time of the day: orders placed before 12 pm might be suggested same day delivery.*
- *Look at past customer order data to determine what app categories the customer has ordered from the Google Play Store and to evaluate if there are certain patterns in products / delivery experience chosen? (e.g. does the customer order small gadgets through same day delivery?)*

4. Onsite Interviews

Question: (follow-up to the previous question)

“Where would you show this delivery options to the customer? At search or checkout? How do you decide this?”

4. Onsite Interviews

Answering Approach:

- *Decision on where to show the delivery options can be made based on user behavior and customer impact. It makes sense to show different delivery options if it will influence choice of products. For example, if there are 5 products shown in results page, do all products have the same delivery option? If yes, then it doesn't make sense to show delivery options as it wont influence consumer decision on products chosen. On the other hand, if 2 products have delivery option, it is important to highlight delivery option for these 2 products because it may be material in consumers' choice of products (these types of answers also shows that you have UX/UI experience which is also very important for Google).*

- *It may also make sense to highlight delivery options in search for certain product categories such as cables etc. where customer values delivery soon.*

- *If the products all have same delivery option, then it can be shown during checkout as it wont change their products chosen.*

4. Onsite Interviews

Question: (follow-up to the previous question)

"What happens if the user is not signed-in?"

Answering Approach:

If the user is not signed-in, use typical customer behavior to guide delivery options either during search / checkout based on the product being ordered. (E.g. recommend same day delivery for Google Pixel Buds.)

Other questions for the onsite interviews

Question: "If you had to go and pitch Google Fiber solution to partners, how would you do it?"

Answering Approach:

Here it is important to layout the high level approach you would take, what data would you use to convince them? How will you influence them and get their buy-in?

Other questions for the onsite interviews

Question: “How would you develop the go-to-market strategy for ____ (specific Google B2B product)?”

Answering Approach:

Outline the key elements of the go-to-market strategy: Product, value proposition / positioning, what channels will you use, what partnerships will you explore? Distribution channels? How will you communicate this?

Other questions for the onsite interviews

Question: “How do you manage territory planning / account management?”

Answering Approach:

Here you will walk them through the process of territory planning and criteria used. How would you measure success?

Other questions for the onsite interviews

Question: What is the value proposition for _____ (Google product that you are interviewing for)?

Question: Tell me about the competitive landscape for _____ (Google product you are interviewing for).

SECTION 3

HOW TO BE SUCCESSFUL IN YOUR INTERVIEWS

FOR MANAGER ROLES AT GOOGLE

Product, Marketing, Account, Ops, Program Managers

HOW TO BE SUCCESSFUL IN YOUR GOOGLE INTERVIEWS

While preparing for my Google interviews, I have researched many resources and found many guides that show you “a system” to beat Google interviews.

I’ve bought them all and studied them thoroughly only to see that they are filled with acronyms like “The ADPLAN method” or seemingly important titles like the “product marketing frameworks” which, in fact, do nothing more than confuse you.

HOW TO BE SUCCESSFUL IN YOUR GOOGLE INTERVIEWS

Here is the best kept “secret” among Google recruiters about our interviews:

During the interviews, Google does not really look at “how knowledgeable or how geek you are” or “how many frameworks you know”.

The most important thing they look at is this: Is this person a clever and hardworking folk who knows what he is doing and also has a nice personality?

Believe me: If you are clever person and you “know what you are doing”, you don’t have to learn all the solution frameworks to be successful in Google interviews.

HOW TO BE SUCCESSFUL IN YOUR GOOGLE INTERVIEWS

During my collaboration with my colleagues at Google when preparing this document, we've seen a question grouping/pattern that was almost the same for everybody.

In the section below you will see the groups of questions that are typically asked to manager / pm / pmm / associate candidates and our (i.e. people who got offers from Google) formulas to answer them.

GROUPS/ TYPES OF QUESTIONS TYPICALLY ASKED DURING THE INTERVIEWS & HOW TO ANSWER THEM

Types of questions asked by Google for managerial roles during interviews:

1. “How do you improve this product or service?”
2. “How do you design X?”
3. “How many X are in Y (e.g. tennis balls in a bus, cellphones in US)”
4. “What is your favorite app/product and why?”
5. “How do you measure X? (e.g. success of a campaign)”
6. “What is the problem here?”
7. “How do you position / sell / market product X?”
8. “Behavioral questions”

1. How do you improve this product or service?

Sample Question: “You are the PM of Facebook's News Feed. How will you select things that are to be shown to any user?”

Approach: For these types of “how do you improve X?” types of questions, we would suggest approaching like this:

1. Ask follow-up questions to clarify the question if necessary.*
2. Analyze what the user behavior/metrics are.
3. Find high priority action items based on these metrics.
4. Compare costs and potential benefits of these alternatives.
5. Decide on the changes/improvements.

* You need to ask follow-up questions for every questions you got. This is important. It shows the recruiter that you like to understand all aspects of the situation exactly before trying to tackle it.

1. How do you improve this product or service?

Sample Question: “You are the PM of Facebook's News Feed. How will you select things that are to be shown to any user?”

Sample Answer:

First of all I would like to clarify if I have any constraints like “for Facebook, it is a must to show the family events”.

(After you get the reply) *In my opinion, it is best to approach this problem from a data-analytics perspective, by creating auto-priority groups for each user and assigning a schedule for each of the groups. As example categorization might be:*

1. How do you improve this product or service?

Sample Question: “You are the PM of Facebook's News Feed. How will you select things that are to be shown to any user?”

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

1. *High priority: A user want to see the posts from this category every time he opens the news feed. (“I can not miss this.”)*
2. *Medium Priority: Occasional views are fine. (“I can miss this, it is ok.”)*
3. *Low priority: Only on a need to know basis. (“I rather not see it.”)*
4. *Blacklisted (“I definitely do not want to see it.”)*

After the categorization, we need to map post types to each user based on their past behavior and his/her specific settings. Some post types may be:

1. How do you improve this product or service?

Sample Question: “You are the PM of Facebook's News Feed. How will you select things that are to be shown to any user?”

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

- *Posts from people that I follow and interact frequently*
- *Posts from people that I follow but did not interact in the last 2 months*
- *Posts that I left a comment*
- *Posts from family*
- *Posts from a group that I follow*
- *Advertisements*
- *Posts from company pages that I like*
- *…*
- *...*

1. How do you improve this product or service?

Sample Question: “You are the PM of Facebook's News Feed. How will you select things that are to be shown to any user?”

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

After the categories are created, we’ll need to assign them to the priority categories based on a number of things given to us by data analysis. (For example let’s say that Eastern cultures are more family oriented, so family posts’ priority initially could be different that Western societies.)

We also also devise an algorithm that will check our assignment of categories periodically and adjust the auto-settings accordingly.

1. How do you improve this product or service?

Sample Question: “You are the PM of Facebook's News Feed. How will you select things that are to be shown to any user?”

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

Note: There is no 1 correct answer to this question and an answer can be as simple as: “I would like to have a simple interface and I would choose to leave all the settings to the use. So on the first page opening, I would list all the possible post types that one can see in his/her News Feed and I would make her select the desired ones with a checkbox.”

The difference between this answer and the first answer is that, in the first one, <u>you try create a structure</u> for selecting posts that will be shown.

Approaching in an analytical and a structured manner is almost always better than finding a quick but clever solution!

----- End of the Answer -----

2. How do you design X?

Sample Question: “Google wants to open an Amazon-Go style cashier-less store to sell its hardware services. How do you design such a store?”

Approach: For “How do you design X?” questions, you can use the following reasoning:

1. Ask follow-up questions to clarify the question if necessary.
2. Analyze who the product is designed for.
3. Analyze what the crucial features are.
4. Do we have the relevant technology or we will need to create it?
5. Compare costs and potential benefits of possible alternative solutions.

Remember: For all of these questions, the recruiter does not really expect you to solve them. Instead, they are looking at your reasoning and analytical thinking skills. Make sure you engage the recruiter while answering the questions and don’t forget to constantly think out loud while solving the problem.

2. How do you design X?

Sample Question: “Google wants to open an Amazon-Go style cashier-less store to sell its hardware services. How do you design such a store?”

Sample Answer:

Got it, so we are going to design an Amazon-Go store, but better, since we are Google, right? ☺ First of all I would like to ask if there are any constraints to the size of the store?

(After you get the reply) *OK, so let’s think: a cashier-less store aims to serve brick-and-mortar store shoppers of all ages by brining convenience and security into their lives. It works by presenting a barcode on your smartphone to a sensor while entering the shop and voila! You can now take whatever you want from the shelves and just go. The receipt will be sent to your smartphone.*

2. How do you design X?

Sample Question: "Google wants to open an Amazon-Go style cashier-less store to sell its hardware services. How do you design such a store?"

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

The store aims to tackle a number of issues:

- *Security (shoplifting)*
- *Speed & convenience (no checkout lines)*

by utilizing advanced sensing technologies (software and hardware).

So the crucial features of the store will be

1. *The ability to sense <u>who</u> is buying an item.*
2. *The ability to understand <u>which item</u> that person is buying.*

2. How do you design X?

Sample Question: “Google wants to open an Amazon-Go style cashier-less store to sell its hardware services. How do you design such a store?”

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

I believe Google has adequate software and hardware solutions to tackle those issues. We do not need to invent new technology: it is a matter of designing the software and hardware interface.

Therefore, the store should be designed with the following features:

- *The store's cameras should include infrared sensors that cover every movement and shopping in the store, which can also measure heat.*

- *The store should be designed in such a way that each item in the store should have a large, camera-friendly code to help the cameras understand which item has been grabbed and the computers will combine that information with data from weight sensors installed in every shelf*

2. How do you design X?

Sample Question: “Google wants to open an Amazon-Go style cashier-less store to sell its hardware services. How do you design such a store?”

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

- *It should also designed in a way that when shoppers are done, they can simply walk back out through the and their phone updates with a receipt, along with a trip timer telling them the time they spent on the shopping trip.*

- *The store should rely on a sophisticated hardware-software interface that will be developed by the Google tech team.*

- *The store should design in a way that Shoppers walking into the store can scan their phone on a subway-station-like turnstile, connecting their presence in the store (as well as their family members or other fellow shoppers) with their individual profile.*

2. How do you design X?

Sample Question: “Google wants to open an Amazon-Go style cashier-less store to sell its hardware services. How do you design such a store?”

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

- *We should definitely apply artificial intelligence and machine learning principles to our store. For example when our systems could not 100% identify what item is being bought by a customer, we should be able to his past purchase data to our benefit. (E.g. if our systems can not decide if the item is ketchup or mustard and the customer’s past purchase data says he frequently buys ketchup, then we should be able to use it to your benefit).*

- *If we have cost concerns, the I would suggest we start with rfid tags on items instead of sophisticated cameras and weight sensing shelves.*

----- End of the Answer -----

3. How many X are in Y?

Sample Question: “How many tennis balls can you fit in a bus?”

Approach: For estimation & calculation questions, you can use the following approach:

1. Ask follow-up questions to clarify the question if necessary.
2. Decide on which simplifications you can make.
3. Use a top -> down or one -> many approach depending on the question.
4. Try to solve the problem as verbal as you can (speaking with the recruiter)

3. How many X are in Y?

Sample Question: “How many tennis balls can you fit in a bus?”

Sample Answer:

Start by asking these questions to the recruiter:

- *What type of bus is this & how big it is?*
- *Am I allowed to remove the seats in it?*
- *Can we squeeze the balls to be airless to fit more?*
- *Can we also fit balls in the trunk/storage cabins in the bus or we are just looking to fill the passenger sitting area?*

3. How many X are in Y?

Sample Question: “How many tennis balls can you fit in a bus?”

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

OKAY, so I am approaching the solution by calculating the volume of 1 tennis ball and the free space in the bus". 1 tennis ball is about 2x2x2 inches = 8 cubic inches (remember that rounding up is OK, they are just looking at your thought process − just don’t throw around huge estimation mistakes).

After this, you calculate the free space in the bus based on your assumptions and then divide..

----- End of the Answer -----

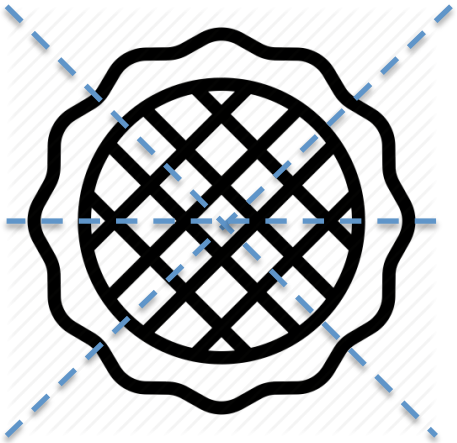
TIP: Sometimes “estimation” questions can be more like “brainteasers”. In those cases you need to think out-of-the-box.

Sample Question: “How can you divide a cake into 8 equal pieces by slicing it with a knife 3 times?”

For these types of questions, the recruiters are tying to see if you are comfortable with unconventional thinking.

Normally it seems that it is not very easy to divide a cake into 8 equal pieces by slicing it only 3 times:

??

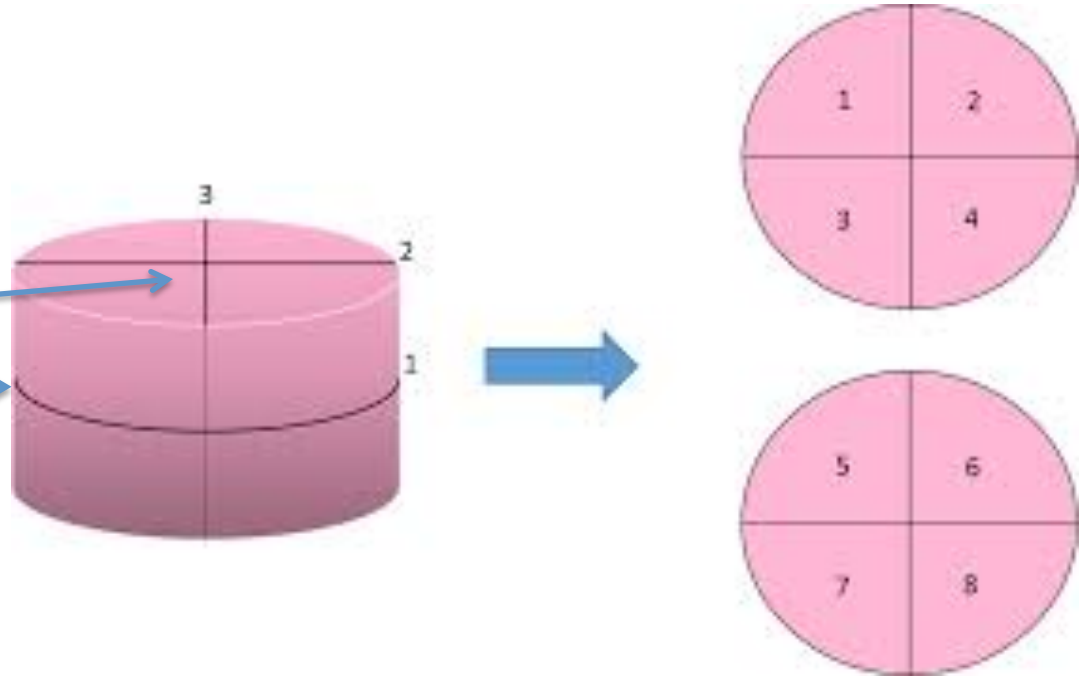


Solution is on the next slide!

“How can you divide a cake into 8 equal pieces by slicing it with a knife 3 times?”

It is actually pretty easy when you think unconventionally. Just forget how you normally divide a cake at home and try to think of other ways:

So, in order the cut the cake into 8 equal pieces, you’ll actually need to cut it twice vertically, and once horizontally.



----- End of the Answer -----

4. What is your favorite app/product and why?

Sample Question: “Tell me, what your favorite Google product and why?”

Approach: For these types of “what is your favorite product” questions, remember the following:

- Ask the recruiter if he/she has a preference for a software product or a hardware product (shows that you like details).
- Do not be overzealous in describing the product. Be natural. (E.g. do not say “omg Gmail is the best thing ever”. Be realistic.)
- Pick a good product you like & know well and list the good features. *Adding an interesting feature that many people may not know is a bonus.*
- List a few improvements you can think of.

4. What is your favorite app/product and why?

Sample Question: “Tell me, what your favorite Google product and why?”

Sample Answer:

Google has many products that people love and use. Of course you have amazing products like Google Fiber, Pixel phones, the Moonshot Projects etc. but I will give Gmail as my favorite product.

There have been many attempts to solve the “productive email app” problem over the years but nothing still comes close to Gmail. All of my friends try new apps from time to time (and don’t get me started on the new Outlook app!) and they always say nothing beats Gmail.

4. What is your favorite app/product and why?

Sample Question: “Tell me, what your favorite Google product and why?”

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

There are a lot of very powerful “hidden” features too, for example just last month I wrote a small script from the Google Scripts page (scripts.google.com) that periodically connects to my Gmail account, finds the archived emails that are not marked as read and then marks them as read, keeping my inbox tidy. That’s an awesome feature!

While there might be some improvements to it like better social integration and more 3rd party apps support (via Gmail Labs), it still is a powerhouse that I can not live without.

----- End of the Answer -----

5. How do you measure X (e.g. success of a campaign/product)?

Sample Question: “We have launched a new feature for Gmail that enables you to group similar messages in your inbox. How will we going to measure the success of this feature?”

Approach: For these types of questions ("how do you measure"), the following approach is recommended:

1. Ask a follow-up question about the specifics of measurement, specifically the definition of what is being measured.
2. Ask if there are any constraints or assumptions you need to make.
3. Define the metrics and prioritize them.
4. If necessary, define a subset of your users that represents the sum.
5. Define the measurement process based on the above data.

5. How do you measure X (e.g. success of a campaign/product)?

Sample Question: “We have launched a new feature for Gmail that enables you to group similar messages in your inbox. How will we going to measure the success of this feature?”

Sample Answer:

First of all, I would like to clarify and agree on what we mean by "success" here. Are we looking for the success of the marketing campaign (i.e. adoption rate) or by success we mean "do users like it"?

Recruiter: I would like you to focus more on the "do users like it" part.

You: Okay, than that means we are not looking the at how the marketing around this feature is successful (i.e. how many users are using it directly due to marketing) but rather how the users find this feature useful. Glad that we cleared that out.

5. How do you measure X (e.g. success of a campaign/product)?

Sample Question: “We have launched a new feature for Gmail that enables you to group similar messages in your inbox. How will we going to measure the success of this feature?”

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

Will this feature be rolled out globally or to some specific users (for example only for G Suite business users)?

Recruiter: Assume it will be global, but on an opt-in basis.

You: Allright. So we are launching a new feature and we need to measure did our users like it or not.
To be able to measure this, we'll need to look at some metrics. The most important metric will be the Churn rate: (How many people stopped using it/ disabled the feature after enabling it)

5. How do you measure X (e.g. success of a campaign/product)?

Sample Question: “We have launched a new feature for Gmail that enables you to group similar messages in your inbox. How will we going to measure the success of this feature?”

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

There are also secondary metrics that can give us an idea about the success of the feature:
- Help Center Feedbacks about this feature
- Social Meda Buzz

Of course, we will have to check these numbers against a similar feature of Gmail so that we have a comparative measurement.

5. How do you measure X (e.g. success of a campaign/product)?

Sample Question: “We have launched a new feature for Gmail that enables you to group similar messages in your inbox. How will we going to measure the success of this feature?”

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

One of the features that can be compared with this new feature is "priority inbox" feature of Gmail. I would say that if the churn rate of this new feature is close to the respective numbers for Priority Inbox, then the feature is successful.

Remember: It is important to know that recruiters are not looking for you to list the maximum number of metrics you can in your interview. Rather, they are looking at your thought process and product/marketing knowledge. So focusing on 1 or two metrics and outlining your plan in a structured manner is the key thing here.

----- End of the Answer -----

6. What is the problem here?

Sample Question: "We have field tested the Google Pixel 3 phones extensively before launch. Average rating given by the testers came out quite low when compared to Pixel 2 phones. Both phones physically look the same (size, screen etc.) and Pixel 3 had more RAM & more storage in addition to having a faster processor. *So it is basically a better Pixel 2*. What might be the cause of low ratings?"

Approach: For these types of questions, it is important to look at the issue from different angles and show your product knowledge.

1. Ask a question for clarification.
2. List the (deliberate) wrong assumptions made by the recruiter if any.
3. List the potential issues and summarize your findings.

6. What is the problem here?

Sample Question: "… What might be the cause of low ratings?"

Sample Answer:

First of all, you mentioned that Pixel 3 is physically look the same. But are they physically completely identical? For example, can you squeeze Pixel 3 like you do in Pixel 2 to access certain features("Active Edge" feature)?

Recruiter: Good question. No, we have removed that feature in Pixel 3.

You: Got it. I know that it was a well-received feature so some of the frustration of users my be due to that. Let's look at other possible factors:

- Design: I know that Pixel 2, especially the 2 XL version looked a bit bulky with some bezel area on top and the bottom. Latest smartphones are going in the "bezel-less" direction, so having the same bulky design similar to the last year might result in low ratings.

6. What is the problem here?

Sample Question: "… What might be the cause of low ratings?"

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

- *Hardware: From the information you gave, processor and RAM have been improved but no changes on the camera front. The camera of Pixel 2 was known to be the best in the industry, so I am guessing it is still pretty good. Many manufacturers, especially Huawei have launched phones with triple cameras, so sticking with only 1 camera might be one of the reasons the users were upset.*

- *Software: The software should be the latest and best Android version, so I am thinking that it wasn't a problem with the users.*

6. What is the problem here?

Sample Question: "… What might be the cause of low ratings?"

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

Based on all the information available, I think the reason for low ratings is due to the fact that Pixel 3 is only an incremental upgrade to the Pixel 2.

The phone is definitely still phenomenal, but especially in the last year, smartphone makers are pushing the boundaries with design and added features like triple cameras and much more sophisticated face recognition.

Users are expecting more and more "wow" factors in their phones, so even though Pixel 3 is a great phone, it scored low with the users due to high expectations being not met.

----- End of the Answer -----

7. How do you position / sell / market X?

Sample Question: “How do you position the Pixel Buds Earphones?”

Approach: For positioning questions, the gold standard is using Moore’s Positioning Framework (this is one of the few frameworks that I actually think useful to remember):

According to the framework, you need to touch these points in your positioning:

1. Our product is for (target customers)
2. Who must (solve a specific problem)
3. Our product is a new (new product category)
4. That provides (key breakthrough benefit vs. current way of doing things – which solves dilemma)
5. Unlike (competitor in new category)
6. We have (whole product most relevant for you)

7. How do you position / sell / market X?

Sample Question: “How do you position / market the Pixel Buds Earphones?”

Sample Answer:

Pixel Buds are a pair of wireless earbuds for design-conscious users who wants more than a simple music listening experience with their earphones. Unlike any other earbuds, Pixel Buds offers real-time translation, voice commands and fast-charging that matches your active lifestyle.

Why this answer is good: It clearly describes what the device is, it’s benefits and differentiating factors from the competition. It also describes the potential user base and targeted “lifestyle” users.

----- End of the Answer -----

8. Behavioral Questions

Sample Question: “Give me an example of a significant professional failure. What did you learn from this situation?”

Approach: Google likes to ask these kind of “failure stories”. The trick here is to be honest. Do not try to conceal a compliment to yourself in your answer (i.e. do not give an answer like: I have issues with work/life balance because I put work above everything and will not rest until a task is done). Be genuine.

Sample Answer:

There was an instance in 2017 where our team failed to sell a project to a potential client. I was Test Lead at that time and I was very closely working with my account manager to secure the sale. It should have been ours, but we dropped the ball.

8. Behavioral Questions

Sample Question: “Give me an example of a significant professional failure. What did you learn from this situation?”

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

I think the biggest issue was that the whole team took it for granted that the project would be ours. We had a good relationship with the client and we had just wrapped up a very successful project for them. A team of us, led by the account manager, went to pitch. It was a solid pitch and we got great feedback.

8. Behavioral Questions

Sample Question: “Give me an example of a significant professional failure. What did you learn from this situation?”

Sample Answer *(continued)*:

At the same time, we failed to truly understand all of the client’s key concerns. They told us that price was the #1 consideration, so we focused on demonstrating cost-effectiveness. But while reducing the cost, our offer lacked some important quality assurances and in the end we lost the sale. It is a good example that thought me not think from a single dimension but consider other aspects as well for any work I'm delivering.

----- End of the Answer -----

SECTION 4

ADDITIONAL QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

In this section, you will find more questions that were asked to me and my colleagues during our pm/pmm interviews, along with our answers/answer approaches.

Please study all the questions and answers. After that, try answering all the questions in your own words. This exercise will definitely help you answer many types of questions you will encounter during your interviews including behavioral questions, product questions, trivia questions and case questions.

Here at Google, how you approach the questions is generally more important than answering the question right. So make sure you try to understand especially "the approach" in the answers.

Good Luck!

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Which Google product do you use/like most? What are the parts that you do not like about it and how will you improve it?

You do not have to try to impress the recruiter by giving the name of an obscure product of Google to show him/her how much you know about Google and its products (many people does that - don't). Be sincere and give an easy answer. Say, for example Gmail. You can say something like "I like Gmail a lot and I use it everyday, but I would like it to be integrated into other Google products more. It has the potential to be the ultimate productivity tool but it has lacking some features. For example, research says that no matter which productivity app (reminders, phone alerts, notes, calendar) people use to organize themselves, in the end people stop using them and resort to plain old email. Better integration around productivity features will make Gmail the single most used tool out there".

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

You have two options: Launch the Google" X" Product in this quarter with some features missing or launch it next quarter with better features but with potential customer drawback (since it is late).

Giving an example from your own background will make sense. Completing a project would mean that I will get a very good rating this quarter but it would also mean that some features would be missing from the product. Instead of completing it this quarter I communicated that it should be completed next quarter. In the end the product was better and I got an "golden star" for my contributions to this awesome product.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

How do you ensure your team stays connected to the company vision?

Communication is key. You need to be in touch with your team all the time. Weekly meetings and status updates ensure that the team & company are in synch. When I realize that an individual goal is in conflict, I sit down with my team member and try to solve the conflict with him. (Solving the conflict without him and telling him what to do instead would make him unhappy)

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

At Google, we like people who goes beyond their job description to help the company in any way they can. Do you have any experience around that?

Our team was using a lot of tools during the day and being a "measuring geek", I was wondering how I was spending my time with the tools. So I created a browser extension that will analyze my usage of the tools. That extension later used by the whole company to optimize our workload.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

How you been in a Team Lead position and assigned a task to a reportee and that turned out to be a bad call?

As a Team Lead, I was assigning tasks to my Team for a mobile testing project and I assigned an eager junior functional tester to a UX testing job. Normally I would not do that but the guy seemed so eager and promised he'll deliver a stellar testing performance. In the end his output was mediocre and it wasn't something our team normally delivers. This thought me to always distribute the jobs according to expertise. If someone is eager but not qualified to do a task, have him trained first to make him qualified for that task and then assign him to the task he wants..

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Here at Google, we rely on data on almost every decision. How can you make important decisions without the help of good & a lot of data?

When there is not much data available, sometimes trends will give you necessary insights. For example, in my last job, I approved spending a budget of X to integrate social media customer support to our regular CSR systems although there wasn't enough data to justify it. But the trends showed that providing support from social media would be big. As a result, my last company was handling 25% of the customer support from social media when I was leaving the company.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

You wouldn't think so, but we make a lot of bad decisions at Google. :) Do you make bad decisions and how do you learn from it?

In the early days of my product management career, during the launch planning stage of a product I was responsible of, I incorrectly assumed that the design deliverables would be ready in two months without asking the UX/UI Team responsible from that task. I based this "two months" assumption on the fact that similar tasks were delivered about 30-45 days from that Team before. Little I was aware of, there was a restructuring going on within that group and they wouldn't be able to deliver the design tasks before two month. I worked with that Team very closely to have the items delivered in 70 days (slight delay) but this was a stressful period both for me and the UI Team. From that they I never "assumed" a delivery time and always checked with the appropriate teams first.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Give an example where you refused to compromise your standards around quality/customer service, etc. Why did you feel so strongly about the situation? What were the consequences? The result?

For one of our products, the headcount number for support operations was 5 people and I got word from my superiors that they wanted to increase the "promised" customer response time from 1 hours to 2 hours in order to reduce workload. I was really against this and knew that customer support is one of the most important things, if not the most, for your business to be successful. I researched research papers and number to justify my claim that if anything, we should be increasing our headcount for support. I gave examples from industry leaders and convinced them to not to change the headcount. Fast forward 1 year, the company was strongly considering to decrease the response time to 30 minutes across board, since my product was the one with the best customer happiness score and the most revenue.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time you took a big risk – what was the risk, how did you decide to do it and what was the outcome?

We were planning the features to put in our soon-to-be updated website for this financial company(i.e. bank) that I was working. I was the head of project and to the amaze of my other colleagues, I said that I would make the frontpage a big search box only. So, there would be no content on the front page but only a search box. This was obviously not seen before, but I thought that our frontpage should be a gateway to our services. I wanted the users to leave the homepage as quickly as possible to their searched product/service (much like google.com) This idea was discussed a lot and in the end the company implemented it. It was a huge success and feedback started to pour in about how simple & fast our website is. Our users liked it a lot and our competitors soon followed suit.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Now Tell me about a time you took a big risk and it failed. What did you learn? What would you do differently?

As a product manager, I decided to use only advertising for the launch of one of our products. Upon management's permission for my "trial" we shifted all our budget to online. After the launch the numbers weren't bad but it was behind similar launches who used online/offline advertising simultaneously. That gave me a lesson to follow the rule of numbers and learn from past (launch) experiences.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

We like out-of-the-box thinking at Google. Give me an example of a radical approach to a problem you proposed. Was your approach successful?

I used to work at a multi national online advertising company with offices in many countries. My team was one of the biggest teams and part of our job was to check incoming applications from users to sign up to our advertising program to include their website in our ad network. That check included an address format check and website check for that particular user. And if we find anything that seems problematic, we would reject the application and sent it back to the customer to fill the information again. These tasks were taking about 20% of our daily activity.

After my 3 months in the company I suggested that we automate those checks as much as we can to save manpower. This was a radical solution because everyone thought that with the complexity involved (just imagine all the different address formats associated with all the different countries / cities) this was an impossible task to accomplish. I became the lead of the project and started managing tech teams, localization teams and different contributing teams from different countries to identify the address formats and stat building the automation software with that data. After an effort of 8 months, we were able to automate 80% of those checks (so, e.g. a tool automatically checks if the address is right for that particular country). The project was a huge success for the company and I was awarded a Platinum Star for that project.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Are you content with "good enough"?

In my prev. Company, we had a rule that says "If you are creating a n page for the website, the total time it takes for the web page to be rendered in a browser window should be less than 1.5 seconds." For one of our projects this number appeared to be 1.55 seconds and the other managers were OK with that. But I know that this wouldn't cut. Web technologies are evolving and Google says many users will be leaving your website if it does not open near-instantly (That's why they are pushing big with AMP and PWA). I consulted with the tech lead and figured out that some optimizations could be done to improve the javascript performance and pressed that this should be done in favor of our users. In the end I was able to convince other managers a swell and as a result of the changes the render time was dropped to 1.42 seconds.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Give me an example of a goal you've had where you wish you had done better. What was the goal and how could you have improved on it?

I think that the key to achieve any goal is to plan early and to plan in detail. At the start of my career I was given some tasks to be completed at a set date but the end result was less optimum than I expected and it was delivered late. From that time on, I started to plan every project early and in detail, counting all the factors as much as possible.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about time you were working on an initiative or goal and saw an opportunity to do something much bigger than the initial focus.

I used to work in a company as the person responsible for online advertising. The initial task given to me was to analyze and improve the ad spending budget. After careful analysis and number crunching, I convinced the upper management to shift focus of advertising spending to online for some of our products because online ads were clearly performing better than traditional ads. So what started as a "relatively" simple online ad spend analysis turned into a fully fledged re-organization of our advertising spend. I was able to achieve this by working above and beyond my line of duty: instead of just looking a to online ad spend numbers, I was curious and looked at other ad budgets & returns as well, thus prompting a larger scope of work for me.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time you looked at a key process that was working well and questioned whether it was still the right one? What assumptions were you questioning and why? Did you end up making a change to the process?

I always look at even very simple tasks and question if they are efficient or not. A simple example of this would be my approach to project management tools. In my previous company, I have realized that my Team was using a pre-formatted excel sheet to keep track of their projects, and their statuses. Although they were very efficient with using Excel, there were newer tools that allows you to collaborate more effectively. I persuaded them to switch to that tool after a while. Although there were some concerns at the beginning, now people swear by it and never look back. (This sample answer also shows that you try to improve even the small things in your work environment as well.)

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

How do you make a frustrated customer happy?

Communication is always the key. You always need to look out for your customers no matter how big is the problem. I've seen many problems with our customers in my previous job, and my approach was always 1. Direct communication 2. Give them a small gift that they will make them happy. The key point here is to make them feel they are being attended to. It always works.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time a customer wanted one thing, but you felt they needed something else. How did you approach the situation, what were your actions and what was the end result?

I always try to understand the problem fully by asking a lot of questions to the customer (in your interview it is important to note that this customer may be an internal customer as well i.e. another team). In these types of scenarios it necessary that you are very knowledgeable about your domain(product). Sample answer: One time a customer called in and asked us to reduce the bill. After my communication with him it turns out that all he wanted to do was to know where his money was going. He wanted to be "in control" of his money. After I explained the bill in detail and our pre-payment notification options, he was more than satisfied and I was also able to sell him another product at the end of our transaction.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time when you went above and beyond the call of duty for a customer. Why did you take the action you did? What was the outcome?

Open with: "Nothing is above and beyond. My duty is to make the customer happy so in all the scenarios I take it as my personal responsibility to help him/her as much as I can." Give an example of calling a customer many times to solve the issue and to make sure that him/her was happy with the outcome.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

How do you go about helping a colleague who is having trouble with coding a products infrastructure?

A new hire was struggling with a piece of messy code. I knew the code was heavy and I could see that he was stressed and did not quite grasp the code fully, but he did not wanted to ask for help in order to be not be seen as incompetent. I offered him my help and helped him dissected the code together. He is now one of our best coders.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about the most innovative thing you've done and why you thought it was innovative.

We were replying to a lot of incoming support emails. I thought that if we place the URL of online support page for that particular question at the end of our email response to that customer, we could "train" the customers to use the online support center more. (i.e. at the end of our reply, writing something like: "Did you now that you can also find the answer of this exact questions on this page on our online support center: ...") This turned out to be very successful in reducing the incoming support emails.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about 1-2 insights you had about internet businesses that were not easy to see 5 years ago.

1. Thought that social media will be big for customer support although it was fairly new. 2. Mobile commerce would be big so my team revamped our mobile app before any competition during 2011.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Give me an example of a time you have provided feedback to develop and leverage the strengths of someone on your team. Were you able to positively impact that person's performance? What were your most effective methods?

I think the key to positively impact someone's performance is to give positive feedback about the things he is happy to hear about. How to find out the things him/her likes to hear: well, that is something you observe during your 1-1's. Once I had this reportee of mine who was managing relationships with the external agencies, I figured out that once you give feedback about "how this or that agency thinks that you are a great communicator" this made her very happy. I used this feedback technique to improve her communication skills even further and in the end she also took the role of "internal comms. manager" in addition to her daily job. She was thrilled to be doing that.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time when you have been unsatisfied with the status quo. What did you do to change it? Were you successful?

You can say that I am obsessed with efficiency. In my last company, we used to have too many meetings and at some stage it felt like we were going to the office to have meetings instead of doing real jobs. Starting with my team, I limited the meetings to 2 half an hour meetings per week. It is amazing to see how efficient the meetings become once you have limited time to discuss all the topics. Instead of typical laid back 1 hour x 5 meetings every week, we were getting the same benefits from the meetings in just 1 hour per week. Of course it did not stop there and I nagged all the managers I can find and by explaining the benefits we had, made them adopt this system as well.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

How do you drive adoption for your vision/ideas? How do you know how well your idea or vision has been adopted by other teams or partners?

Communication and the persuasive power of the numbers. Having good communication lines open goes a long way in persuading people for your project. Having numbers backing up your idea is the sure-fire way of getting people on your side.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Give me an example of a calculated risk that you have taken where speed was critical. What was the situation and how did you handle it? What steps did you take to mitigate the risk? What was the outcome?

One time we were about to launch a product live and just got a "you need to stop this" alert from the tech team saying that they have found a bug. It was just minutes left for the project to go live and I could not get a handle of my manager (no phone reception). I quickly sat down with the tech managers and tried to understand the bug and it's possible effects. It was an important bug that needed to be fixed.

Due to my technical background, I knew that this would be a problem when we have more than 10.000 concurrent users on the system which was not expected at least in the first 10 days. The Tech Team assured me that they can fix it in 3 days so I went ahead and gave the project a go. After the project is live, the Tech Team implemented a fix in 2 days so everything turned out to be fine in the end. Should I went ahead and halted the project it would be a much bigger problem for the company.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Do you have an experience where you had to make tradeoffs between quality and cost. How did you weigh the options? What was the result?

In my previous company, we were building a website for our project that sells skin supplies for men & women. We had two options, either use a standard cms provider (shopify or wordpress) or build our own custom design from scratch. Building from scratch meant that the website will obviously look much better but it would cost 3 months to develop (thus more costly). Going with Shopify meant that the design would not be as perfect but it will be much less costly and we would be able to start selling earlier.

We decided to start with Shopify and actually realized that we were putting too much emphasis on design, which wasn't necessary. We were able to customize the look and feel of our Shopify store and it matched 80% of our expectations, design-wise. In the end we did not changed the design to a custom one at all. Shopify was sufficient for us...

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Describe a time when you needed the cooperation of a peer or peers who were resistant to what you were trying to do. What did you do? What was the outcome?

When I see some resistance from my team mates, instead of being defensive, I always try to understand the underlying reasons of their attitude. We should not let this difference of opinion divide us for our current and future projects. (Here, you must show to the recruiter that you communicated with those people to find out the reason behind their resistance ad solved it.)

For example: In my previous company, we had a corporate website, and I thought that we must revamped to reflect the current design standards and technologies. My team mates were really resistant to the idea. After talking with them it turned out that they also think the website should be updated, but they thought this project will make them work extra long hours to be completed. I persuaded them by finding a common ground between project completion time and necessary overtime.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a problem you had to solve that required in-depth thought and analysis? How did you know you were focusing on the right things?

Example: In my previous company, we had an online service that we sell to our customers. No matter what the age group 30-45 did not adopt the product as much as we would like them to be. After a through analysis based on many things (online spending habit of that demographics, shopping funnel and dropout pages in the website, cross-checking of their usage behaviors on our other products) we were able to identify the culprit and by amending it we were able to increase sales for that demographic.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Give me an example of a time when you were able to deliver an important project under a tight deadline. What sacrifices did you have to make to meet the deadline? How did they impact the final deliverables?

Example: "We landed on a project that was not originally part of program deliverable and came as a sudden request from a vendor. It needed to be delivered in 3 weeks. My role was to make sure the testing is not compromised due to shorter timeline and making sure that we were able to complete on time. We sacrificed - worked in weekends and started the performance testing early. In the end we were able to successfully compete testing on time.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

When do you decide to go along with the group decision even if you disagree? Give me an example of a time you chose to acquiesce to the group even when you disagreed. Would you make the same decision now?

The trick here is similar to some other answers below: You had to follow the decision due to budget/time/headcount limitations, but showed the management (using analysis & numbers) that the company should think ahead and prioritize this from going on.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Give me an example of a significant professional failure. What did you learn from this situation?

There was an instance in 2012 where our team failed to sell a project to a potential client. I was Test Lead at that time and I was very closely working with my account manager to secure the sale. It should have been ours, but we dropped the ball.

I think the biggest issue was that the whole team took it for granted that the project would be ours. We had a good relationship with the client and we had just wrapped up a very successful project for them. A team of us, led by the account manager, went to pitch. It was a solid pitch and we got great feedback.

At the same time, we failed to truly understand all of the client's key concerns. They told us that price was the #1 consideration, so we focused on demonstrating cost-effectiveness. But while reducing the cost, our offer lacked some important quality assurances and in the end we lost the sale. It is a good example that thought me not think from a single dimension but consider other aspects as well for any work I'm delivering.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Customer feedback is very important for us and Google gets zillions of product feedback. Tell us how you would create a meaningful data from your products customers, assuming you do not have access to to machine learning and other sophisticated tools.

In my previous company, we used to take customer feedback from different resources and they were really too many to go through all of them. I asked the Tech Team to unify the feedback into one big pool and asked them to write an application which will give me the word cloud of the feedback text. Using that word cloud I realized that a lot of people were complain about 4-5 different areas and then I implemented improvements for them. The customer complaints ceased after the implementation.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Give me an example of a time when you didn't think you were going to meet the commitments you promised. How did you identify the risk and communicate it to stakeholders? What was the outcome?

Numbers, numbers and numbers. Always provide numbers and analysis to your stakeholders to get their consent about everything. Constant communication is also key here. Important tip: I used to create an email list for my project and made it a habit of constantly updating the stakeholder with the latest status of the project.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

How do you automate a manual task that has been done by various Google offices around the globe? How do you go about the process?

Giving an example is key here: "While I was working on a multinational company, I had the idea of automating a really manual job across all regions. The task was to automate the approval of customer addresses. The task was really hard due to different formats of the addresses each country uses. After careful planning we created a task force that included people from all different nationalities and manage to complete the project by constant communication and hard work. It reduced the manual workload of address checking by 20% globally." And then explain the details about how you automated it: how did you find the best solution, how did you manage to get all the teams in different time-zones together etc.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time when you have been faced with a challenge where the best way forward or strategy to adopt was not “clear cut” (i.e. there were a number of possible solutions). How did you decide the best way forward?

Monitoring Social Media for your product/company is now ubiquitous. Back in the day when this process was new to everybody, I proposed that we watch social media for comments and feedbacks about this product we were launching. We had a problem though: No one knew what to do with the feedback received and how to reply to customer comments on social media.

There were many strategies to adopt and all had a certain amount of risk associated with them. In the end we choose the "the path that puts the customer first no matter what", i.e. reply to them on social media immediately and try your best to make them happy (and thus turn them into product advocates). This proved to be the best mid-term strategy to adopt boosting our" love mark" scores.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a particular complex problem you solved with a simple solution.

The answer above fits here as well: We were replying to a lot of incoming support emails. I thought that if we place the URL of online support page for that particular question at the end of our email response to that customer, we could "train" the customers to use the online support center more. (i.e. at the end of our reply, writing something like: "Did you now that you can also find the answer of this exact questions on this page on our online support center: ...") This turned out to be very successful in reducing the incoming support emails.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time you made a difficult decision and how you knew it was the right solution.

Shifting all newspaper advertising budget to online advertising. I knew that measurable advertising mediums is the future so I decided to move all the print advertising budget to online advertising in my previous company. Faced a lot of drawback while doing this but in the end number showed that it was a right decision. (probe on how you evaluated the options, if you received input, what data you reviewed, etc.)

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me how you help your team members develop their careers. Can you give me two to three examples of specific people in whom invested and how you helped them develop their careers including one who wasn't being successful but you saw potential and chose to invest?

Communication is key. My secret here is during my first meeting, I always ask this question to my reportees: "What motivates you?" Trying the understand the driving force of people and keeping the communication lines open always works. In my last company I came across a reportee of mine who seemed stubborn and his performance has dropped in the last two months. Other managers did not know what to do before me and were thinking of letting him go.

With my "constant & open communication" approach, I actually learned from him that he was really unhappy because he though he would be promoted into my spot instead of an external hire (me). I communicated to him that other managers were thinking he was lacking a few aspects for team management and promised to work with him very closely to improve his skillset. After 2 years, I was promoted to lead another team and this guy told me that he was very lucky to be working with me and he improved in ways he would not imagine. And of course he was promoted to my spot after I left.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Describe the most significant, continuous improvement project that you have led. What was the catalyst to this change and how did you go about it?

I used to work at a multi national online advertising company with offices in many countries. My team was one of the biggest teams and part of our job was to check incoming applications from users to sign up to our advertising program to include their website in our ad network. That check included a name check, address format check and website check for that particular user. And if we find anything that seems problematic, we would reject the application and sent it back to the customer to fill the information again. This task was taking about 20% of our daily activity.

After my 3 months in the company I suggested that we automate those checks as much as we can to save manpower. I became the lead of the project and started managing tech teams, localization teams and different contributing teams from different countries. After an effort of 8 months, we were able to automate 80% of those checks (so, e.g. a tool automatically checks if the address is right for that particular country). The project was a huge success for the company and I was awarded a Platinum Star for that project.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time where you felt your team was not moving to action quickly enough. What did you do? (Manager)

Always try to understand the reason behind this by communication. Never say something like "I tried to motivate them by giving incentives" as your initial approach. You can give incentives or use other methods, but google likes to hear that you tired to communicate with your team to understand the root cause of the problem.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Give me an example of how you have helped save costs or eliminate waste within your operation.

My motto here is: "If there is a more efficient way of doing things, it almost always shows itself." This answer could be something like the answer above (saving headcount by not utilizing liaisons for communicating with the tech team).

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Describe a time when you significantly contributed to improving morale and productivity on your team. What were the underlying problems and their causes? How did you prevent them from negatively impacting the team in the future?

In my previous company we were about to launch a product and there was a big pressure on our Team of 5 people. Just two weeks before the launch date, one of team members had to leave for family emergency and another one broke his arms in an accident. The Team was really demoralized and thought that we were never able to make it for the launch deadline. It was up to me to keep the morale high and make the team deliver on time.

What I did is, I announced that the upcoming 2 weeks is the "happy & fun product launch extravaganza and sort of made it a team building activity. I also asked for extra hands from a few teams that we were working close on this project and as a result we were able to finish the product on time. Now my Team thinks that anything is possible if you approach it with a "go-getter" attitude..

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time you were trying to understand a problem on your team and you had to go down several layers to figure it out. Who did you talk with and what information proved most valuable? How did you use that information to help solve the problem?

(Tip: You need to show that you are persistent with your research.) In my company I am know to go the extra mile to fix things that I put my mind to. Sometimes your team mates will be reluctant to tell you the real story because they will think it can be embarrassing, but with open communication you will be able to get the details.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time you had significant, unanticipated obstacles to overcome in achieving a key goal. Were you eventually successful?

In my previous company we were about to launch a product and there was a big pressure on our Team of 5 people. Just two weeks before the launch date, one of team members had to leave for family emergency and another one broke his arms in an accident. The Team was really demoralized and thought that we were never able to make it for the launch deadline. It was up to me to keep the morale high and make the team deliver on time.

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Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Give me an example of an idea you had that was strongly opposed. Why was there so much resistance? How did you handle the negative feedback?

Common examples here include "management were skeptical of new ways of doing things". So based on your experience or your extensive analysis, you have found/suggested a new approach but it was rejected. Another important point here is about rejection: Always say something in the lines of "I accepted rejection gracefully but I was able to have them accept my idea after a while with help of my improved analysis/data."

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Most of us at one time or another have felt frustrated or impatient when dealing with customers. Can you tell us about a time when you felt this way and how you dealt with it?

Happens a lot. You need to show here that you don't loose your temper and you can manage these situations well. My response: "I ask for a pause, take a step back and analyze who/what will be affected with this and how it can be resolved. Then return back to the customer with your solution". Sample answer: One time a team that provides us the products specs changed them completely but the management(customer in this case) still wanted the product to be ready in 1 month.

I took a step back made a quick analysis of the situation. Presented the management with my report backed up with numbers (numbers are always important) and ask them either to delay the product due date or pick some features to be left off. Seeing my numbers and my analysis they were cooperative in the end.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

What steps do you take to ensure projects you complete get transitioned effectively to new owners? Give an example where you elected to re- engage on a project that you had already transitioned to someone else. What was the situation and why did you feel it was important to re-engage?

Important to note that you have the habit of starting the documentation from day 1. "I had a project that was delivered successfully and I gave transition to Business Owners as it went to maintenance mode. After 3 months , I started seeing defects which were not seen before and I kind of sensed it something was missed, access was not properly configured." With the help of my documentation I was able to help the new team pinpoint the issue in a short time.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Describe a challenging problem or situation in which the usual approach was not going to work. Why were you unable to take the usual approach? What alternative approach did you take? Was it successful?

When a customer tweets about a bad service they get from us. We have a procedure for our customer support team to get in touch with that person using private messaging on Twitter and solve their problem. This one time the complaining customer was kind of an internet celebrity.

Using standard customer support procedures would make him "feel like an ordinary person" so I suggested that we create another procedure for internet celebrities that included contacting them from a VP level. Internet celebrities were very happy for being contacted by a high profile employees and they even now praise us on social media due to this.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time when you have worked to improve the quality of a product / service / solution that was already getting good customer feedback? Why did you think it needed continued improvement?

There is always room for improvement! I used to work at an online marketplace and the sale numbers were quite good. The thing with online websites and mobil websites is, the technology is constantly evolving and new solutions for faster products appear constantly. So our mobile website was pretty decent and did have good loading times, and the customers were loving it. But I started a project to convert it to Google AMP (Accelerated Mobile Pages) and Google PWA (Progressive Web Apps). This enabled our mobile website to be future proof, enabling us to concentrate on other tasks to grow the business.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time when you were able to remove a serious roadblock/barrier preventing your team from making progress? How were you able to remove the barrier? What was the outcome? (Manager)?

My team was working with different branches of the tech team on a project and the way things are setup, they use a "liaison" for every branch. The project was time sensitive and going through this extra layer of communication was clearly making things slower. For this project, I proposed that we skip the liaison officers and communicate directly with the tech people.

Management was reluctant but I showed them this change will be for the better by communication with only one branch without a liaison. After they saw that things were moving much faster with that tech branch & us, they allowed us to work with no liaison officers for all the branches within the tech team in our project.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time you didn't have enough resources to do something you felt was important but found a creative way to get it done anyway. What drove you to seek out creative solutions?

Similar to the answer to the questions above: We needed a tool to analyze the incoming support mails and send an auto reply with the matching online help center information. Our tech team reported that they do not have enough resources for this so I had to be creative and stated to insert the online help center links manually to our outgoing replies. The rate of incoming mails dropped around 20% in two months.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Give an example of a time you requested additional funding/budget to complete a project. Why was it needed? Did you try to figure out another approach? Did you get the additional resources? Why or why not?

The key point here is that you need to backup your requests with detailed analysis and you need to show the recruiter that your efforts to increase the budget was finally successful. For example: "For a product launch, I asked the management to increase the UX/UI design budget. It was denied initially but after the post-launch analysis, they saw that the extra budget would have been useful and they were OK with increasing the budget for the future projects."

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about how you have effectively built trusting working relationships with others on your team.

Communication and "I always got your back" attitude is key. You also need to lead by example. When your team mates see that you are a hard working person, a respectful relationship starts to build.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time when you linked two or more problems together and identified an underlying issue? Were you able to find a solution?

The problem was that there was a big backlog in incoming support center emails and we were not able to answer questions on time. Also, we figured out that our customers just sent us an email when they had a small issue without even looking at the online help center. In order to solve these two problems we started a program to "educate" our users about the online help center and we made the "send us an email" link harder to find. In turn, customers started to spend more time in the online help center pages and number of incoming emails reduced significantly.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Walk me through a big problem or issue in your organization that you helped to solve. How did you become aware of it? What information did you gather, what information was missing and how did you fill the gaps? Did you do a post mortem analysis and if you did what did you learn?

Back in my last company which was a financial institution, there was an issue with feedbacks about strange account balance abnormalities. Some customers were saying that their balances were off by a cent or so. This of course was a big issue and the company couldn't figure out what the problem was.

I was a new employee working on operations but I volunteered and worked with the tech team and after careful analysis, we have found out that the error was happening due to our (older) systems rounding the numbers to 2 significant digits after the zero. We have changed it to be 4 significant digits and solved the problem. This was actually a huge problem for the company and if it were to continue for a while, the company would have major backlash in the media.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Can you tell me about a specific metric you have used to identify a need for a change in your department? Did you create the metric or was it already available? How did this and other information influence the change?

In my previous company we were working with many internal tools (software apps) and I was thinking that we were spending more time in tool X than we should have. I am not a coder normally, but I learned to create a Firefox browser extension and I coded a small extension for myself to analyze which tools I am using most.

Based on my findings, I went to my manager and told him that we should be spending less time in tool X and rather spend more time in tool Y. The manager was very interested and after trying my browser extension on all of my team mates computers, it was clear that we were allocating our time inefficiently and changed our way of working with our tools.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a goal that you set that took a long time to achieve or that you are still working towards. How do you keep focused on the goal given the other priorities you have?

A typical example for this will be a business transformation tasks. They always take long so the correct approach to this question is "you need to divide the tasks into small pieces with deadlines so it would seem like many micro-projects." This strategy keeps the motivations up.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time you had to get something done with half or two thirds of the resources you thought you'd need for the project or initiative.

In my opinion, properly motivated people will be nearly 2 times as efficient as a regular person. (By motivation I do not necessarily mean an incentive, it could very well be a "happy" team). To answer this questions, always mention that you are used to working in similar environments, where you finish your project "startup style" with little or no resources. Then talk about a project where you were able to motivate the team to perform in a much more efficient manner for that project.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a piece of direct feedback you recently gave to a colleague. How did he or she respond? How do you like to receive feedback from coworkers or managers?

There is a misconception about feedback that it almost always is negative. Here, you can surprise your recruiter by directly telling a positive feedback you gave to your team mates. For example: I had a colleague that used to work in a very organized fashion. I gave her direct feedback about how I find this habit a very useful one, and I told her she should be sharing her practices with the rest of the team. She was not expecting this and it contributed to her performing above expectations that quarter.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

When do you think it's appropriate to push back or say no to an unreasonable customer request? Can you give me an example of when you've been able to see around the corner to meet a customer need or delight a customer with a solution or product they didn't yet know they needed/wanted?

It is important to know that to be able to understand if a request is unreasonable, you REALLY know your product and your teams well. For internal customers: use numbers to influence them. For external customers: communication is key. Same answer to "Tell me about a time a customer wanted one thing, but you felt they needed something else. How did you approach the situation, what were your actions and what was the end result?" applies here as well.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time you were able to make something significantly simpler for customers. What drove you to implement this change?

While I was working at a bank, I implemented a solution for our customers to send another person money by a simple text message. A code is received by the other person and he/she can withdraw the money from an ATM without using a bank card. I found this solution as a way fro parents to send money for their kids in school when they need it and to became vey popular among parents and their kids in school. "Dad I ran out of money. "Here is your code, you can instantly use any ATM to withdraw 50 USD without using a bank card""

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time when you took on something significant outside your area of responsibility. Why was it important? What was the outcome?

I realized that using outlook email significantly reduced the efficiency of the whole company (more than 3000) people. So I "lobbied" with the tech team and moved the company to Slack for internal communications and that really helped a lot with our workflows. "This may seem insignificant or not may responsibility but I take it as a personal duty to improve all aspects of my work/company."

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Give me an example of one of the best hires of your career. How did this person progress through their career? What did you identify during the hiring process that drove his or her success?

One time I was stuck between two candidates to hire for an important ass. Manager position. One had a college degree from an Ivy League school and the other barely made it through the college. I liked the humbleness, openness and humility of the second candidate.

He sincerely looked like a hard worker whereas the pother candidate (still a good prospect) did kind of seemed entitled. In the end I ended up hiring the barely-out-of-college student and he became the top performer among his colleagues. So I now always look for personality traits as much, if not more, than education credentials when doing a hiring.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time when you had to analyze facts quickly, define key issues, and respond immediately to a situation. What was the outcome?

One time we were about to launch a product live and just got a "you need to stop this" alert from the tech team saying that they have found a bug. It was just minutes left for the project to go live and I could not get a handle of my manager (no phone reception). I quickly sat down with the tech managers and tried to understand the bug and it's possible effects. It was an important bug that needed to be fixed.

Due to my technical background, I knew that this would be a problem when we have more than 10.000 concurrent users on the system which was not expected at least in the first 10 days. The Tech Team assured me that they can fix it in 3 days so I went ahead and gave the project a go. After the project is live, the Tech Team implemented a fix in 2 days so everything turned out to be fine in the end. Should I went ahead and halted the project it would be a much bigger problem for the company.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Give me an example of how you have changed the direction or view of a specific function/department and helped them embrace a new way of thinking? Why was a change needed?

6-7 years ago, when social media was relatively new, Customer Service Department's didn't know much about social media monitoring or SM customer support. As the head of marketing, I worked with them and helped them to embrace the new "social" way of customer support. (Which is a huge thing now)

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time when you have worked against tight deadlines and didn't have the time to consider all options before making a decision. How much time did you have? What approach did you take?

Here, you'll need to show that, if you do not have access to all options, make sure that the options you have will give you a significant indication. The approach should be: "I knew that I did not analyzed all the options, but I knew that the options I have were enough to give me a good confidence level on my decision. Numbers never lie."

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time when you generated a creative solution to a problem or project without requiring additional resources. What was the problem? What was the solution and how did you come up with it?

In my previous company, one of my team's responsibilities was to answer incoming support emails. There were thousands of emails in the queue and we were struggling to catch up with them. The problem was we had a pretty good online help center but people was not using it, sending us questions that would be easily found in the help center FAQ. I came up with a project to "educate" the customers by sending them the help center links in the reply emails in addition to our answers. The rate of incoming mails dropped around 20% in two months.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Give an example of a time where you were not able to meet a commitment to a team member. What was the commitment and what prevented you from meeting it? What was the outcome and what did you learn from it?

During the early stages of my career, I over-promised to a teammate to finish a task for him in two weeks. I already had more than I could handle but I thought I need to push hard to impress with my performance in the company. It was a misjudgment on my side and I failed to deliver the task on time. It did not reflect good on my review but thought me an important lesson: Know your limits and do not exaggerate what you can do. Learning to say no is important and it is better to say no to a task than not being able to deliver it.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time you had to communicate a big change in direction for which you anticipated people would have a lot of concerns. How did you handle questions and/or resistance? Were you able to get people comfortable with the change?

In my previous company, the management decided to change the bonus structure and decided to tie to the individuals quarterly rating instead of the teams performance factor. In these types of changes, first of all you need to understand all the details and its effects in detail before facing your team to announce the news. Here it is also important to know that sometimes you can not make everybody happy and that is OK.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time you (and your team if Manager) were driving toward a goal and were more than half way to the objective when you realized it may not be the best or right goal or may have unintended consequences. What was the situation and what did you do?

For a vendors project, the testing was not going the way its intended to go. It used to be the waterfall model but we changed the methodology to sprint in middle. It enabled us to finish the project on time. (Here the important thing is you need to show that you are a person that constantly checks the status of the project & and you are able to see the problems ahead.)

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time that you strongly disagreed with your manager on something you deemed to be very important to the business. What was it about and how did you handle it?

The answer that seems to get the most positive response from the recruiters is that: When you have a disagreement with your manager, you'll need to persuade him to test your idea in smaller doses. Managers who resists ideas or changes will almost always agree to a small test to see if your idea is correct. Give an example about a scenario where you persuaded your manager to do a small test initially, and then he/she supported your idea after he saw the results.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Give me an example of when you took an unpopular stance in a meeting with peers and your leader and you were the outlier. What was it, why did you feel strongly about it, and what did you do?

For one of our product launches, we were deciding how big the support center team will be. The management and other team members said that an SLA of "answering each query in max 1 hour" was enough, but I said customers are everything for us so we should make the SLA around 30 minutes, meaning we would have to double the support team. Due to budget constraints I was not able to persuade them at that time. After 6 months, due to customer complaints, we had to double the support team as I requested back then...

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Describe a time where you felt really strongly about something but ultimately lost the argument. How hard did you press the issue? What was your approach after you lost the argument?

The key point here is to let the recruiters know that you are a "numbers" person. You based your decision on numbers and analysis, but lost the argument due to "intuition" of your managers. After this you have two options, depending on the question, you can continue with "but the manager's decision was right and it was a big learning for me" or "later on we saw that, if implemented, my solution would be better. This changed the perception of my manager on how do they look at my decisions. It was a big win for me”.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time the business gained something because you persisted for a length of time. Why were you so determined? How did it turn out?

Here you need to show that you persisted either: 1. You have solid data and analysis to back your claim up or 2. You have a vast or specific experience about the issue in hand.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time where someone has openly challenged you. How did you handle this feedback?

In my previous company I promoted "Mark" and "Gary" was upset about it. Gary thought that he deserved the promotion instead of Mark and was openly criticizing me that I made the wrong call and I was not really fair. Instead of being angry with him, I sat down with him and shoed my notes and performance ratings of both of them to Gary. He clearly was missing some skills to be promoted and he accepted fact. I told him that he has a lot of potential and motivated him to improve so in the end he left our meeting happy.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time you made a significant mistake. What led you to making the wrong decision? What would you have done differently in retrospect?

As a Team Lead, I was assigning tasks to my Team for a mobile testing project and I assigned an eager junior functional tester to a UX testing job. Normally I would not do that but the guy seemed so eager and promised he'll deliver a stellar testing performance. In the end his output was mediocre and it wasn't something our team normally delivers. This thought me to always distribute the jobs according to expertise no matter how eager a promising team mate is. If someone is eager but not qualified to do a task, have him trained first to make him qualified for that task and then assign him to the task he wants..

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Give an example of a tough or critical piece of feedback you received. What was it and what did you do about it?

The trick here is to let the recruiter know that: You take the feedback with a positive attitude, break it down to see the reasons behind this feedback and approach to improve upon those small pieces.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time you received feedback with which you didn't agree. How did you react?

Use this wording: "I am a person who is pretty open for constructive feedback. The ones I do not agree are basically data related ones. If I have a pretty detailed analysis based on numbers and someone criticizes it, I do openly not agree with it. Most of the times, if that person is open to it, I try to to sit down with the person who gave that feedback and run the numbers together."

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about time you had to learn something outside your comfort zone in order to drive results for your organization or to adapt to a change in the market, organization or other catalyst.

A good example for this question will be something like this: During the early stages of my career, you would say I was a typical new grad. I was used to do what I was assigned and did not really look into ways to improve myself on anything else. One thing I was not comfortable with was constantly following up with others teams and ask them if they completed a task I was waiting for. Doing this constant "nagging" really made me feel uncomfortable. Once I started to communicate more openly with other teams (be their friends) this embarrassing feeling of "nagging" people switched to a feeling of friends asking friends information about a project. Thus my best lesson in my professional life: Communication is key to solving nearly all types of problems!

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

To try to meet the high expectations of our customers, we sometimes promise more than we can deliver. Tell me about a time when you overcommitted yourself or your company. How did you resolve the issue?

Sincerity is the key. Communicate that you really wanted to help but overlooked some aspects of the work. Admitting honestly that you overcommitted yourself is not a bad thing. You come up with an alternative solution to your customer "before" the deadline is reached. If you think you maybe have overcommitted, do not forget to communicate with the customer constantly and keep them updated. If your customer is "in the know" of the latest status, he/she will be more understanding.

Additional Questions & Sample Answers/Tips

Tell me about a time when you had to balance the needs of the customer vs. the needs of the business. How did you manage this situation?

In these types of situations, it is important to analyze if the needs of that particular customer is the need of all the customers (i.e. its impact). If so, then make necessary changes, if not, bias towards the company's needs. Saying this is important because this is not a typical answer and recruiters love these kinds of "out of the box" answers. Do not go and blindly say "I will do this and this to balance the needs of both sides”.

Thank You!